

THE SHIELD

Scutum



SIZE RANKING 84

BRIGHTEST STAR

Alpha (α) 3.8

GENITIVE Scuti

ABBREVIATION Sct

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
July–AugustFULLY VISIBLE
74°N–90°S

This minor constellation is situated in a rich area of the Milky Way, between Aquila and Sagittarius, south of the celestial equator. It was introduced by Johannes Hevelius (see p.384) in the late 17th century. He gave it the name *Scutum Sobiescianum*, meaning Sobieski's Shield, to honor his patron, King John Sobieski of Poland.

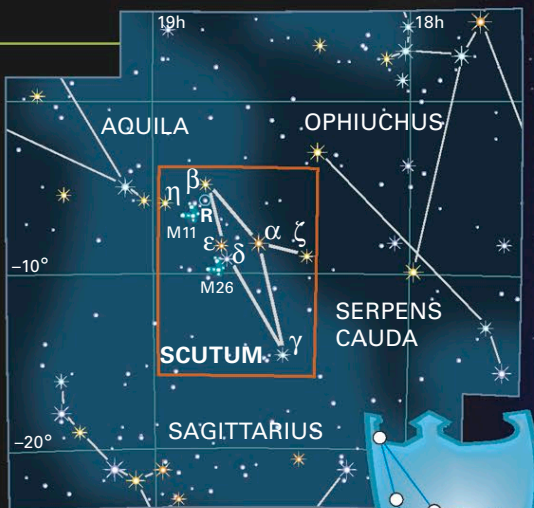
SPECIFIC FEATURES

Delta (δ) Scuti is the prototype of a class of variable star that pulsates in size every few hours, changing brightness by only a few tenths of a magnitude. Delta itself varies between magnitude 4.6 and 4.8 in less than 5 hours, but the change is only detectable with sensitive instruments. Far more obvious is R Scuti, an orange supergiant that rises and falls between magnitudes 4.2 and 8.6 in a 20-week cycle.

Near R Scuti is the beautiful Wild Duck Cluster (M11), which appears as a smudgy glow half the apparent width of a full moon when viewed through binoculars. This open cluster gained its popular name because its

SCUTUM STAR CLOUD ☞

One of the brightest parts of the Milky Way lies in Scutum and is known as the Scutum Star Cloud. The bright spot at center left is the Wild Duck Cluster.

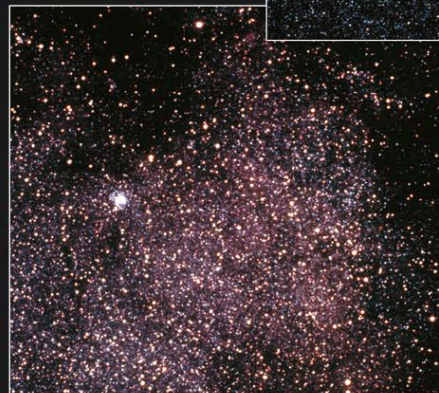


THE SHIELD

stars form a fan shape, like a flock of ducks in flight, when seen through a small telescope. Near the apex of the fan is an 8th-magnitude red giant. The Wild Duck Cluster is in an area of the constellation that is known as the Scutum Star Cloud. This rich star field is located just south of Beta (β) Scuti.

WILD DUCKS ☞

Seen through a small telescope, M11 looks like the V-shaped flight pattern of wildfowl. This effect is less apparent on photographs.



SOBIESKI'S SHIELD ☞

Scutum has no bright stars of its own, but it lies in an area of the Milky Way, between Aquila and Sagittarius, that is particularly rich with stars.

THE ARROW

Sagitta



SIZE RANKING 86

BRIGHTEST STAR

Gamma (γ) 3.5

GENITIVE Sagittae

ABBREVIATION Sge

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
AugustFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–69°S

Sagitta was known to the ancient Greeks, who believed it represented an arrow shot by either Apollo, Hercules, or Eros. It is the third-smallest constellation, lying in the Milky Way between Vulpecula and Aquila in the northern sky. It is faint and easily overlooked.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

There is little of note in Sagitta for users of small instruments. Zeta (ζ) Sagittae is a 5th-magnitude star with a 9th-magnitude companion that is visible in a small telescope, but it is not a particularly impressive double. S Sagittae is a Cepheid variable that halves in brightness every 8.4 days before recovering again, as it swings between magnitudes 5.2 and 6.0.

Midway along the shaft of the arrow is M71, a modest globular cluster detectable with binoculars but better seen through a telescope. M71 lacks the central condensation typical of most globulars and instead looks more like a dense open cluster.

WZ Sagittae is a dwarf nova variable (see Novae, p.282). It is rarely in outburst.

ARROW IN FLIGHT ☞

The small arrow Sagitta flies over the stars of Aquila, the eagle, and toward Delphinus, the dolphin.

THE ARROW

